

Iran



Known as Persia until 1935, Iran blends theocratic government with modern nationalism.

533 BCE **Cyrus the Great** unites the Medes and Persians to form the first great Persian Empire, which is ruled by the Achaemenid dynasty and is conquered by Alexander of Macedon (Alexander the Great) in 331 BCE.

224 CE **The Sassanian Empire** is founded, posing a serious military threat to the eastern Roman Empire. The ancient Zoroastrian religion becomes predominant.

637–641 CE **The Sassanian Empire** is conquered by Muslim Arabs. Persia is Islamized, but fragments politically.

1502 **The Safavid Empire** is founded by Ismail Safavi, and Persia again becomes a political entity, and a military rival to Ottoman Turkey. Shia Islam becomes the established religion of the state.

1587–1629 **Under Shah Abbas I** Safavid Persia reaches the apogee of its power. The royal capital of Isfahan is adorned with mosques and new public buildings.

1779 **Fath Ali Shah** founds the Qajar dynasty, which rules Persia until 1926.

1814 **The Treaty of Tehran** is concluded with Great Britain to protect Persian territories from unprovoked aggression.

1906 **Demands for reform** lead to the so-called Constitutional Revolution and the establishment of a Constituent National Assembly (or Majlis), freedom of the press, and security of property tenure.

1908 **The Anglo-Persian Oil Company** is founded.

1920 **Bolshevik Russian forces** invade the Caspian province of Gilan.

1921 **Reza Khan**, the leader of the Persian Cossack Brigade, seizes power. A peace treaty is signed with Soviet Russia.

1925 **Reza Khan becomes** shah and establishes the Pahlavi dynasty. He embarks on a major reform program of modernization and Westernization, but becomes increasingly reliant on Germany for support. In 1935 he changes the country's name from Persia to Iran.

1941 **The United Kingdom** and the Soviet Union invade Iran, and in September the Shah is forced to abdicate in favor of his son, Muhammad Reza Pahlavi.

1951 **The nationalist regime** of Mohammad Mossadeq comes to power. The oil industry is nationalized, causing grave friction with the US and UK.

1953 **An American-backed coup** overthrows Mossadeq. The Shah returns with Anglo-American backing.

1957 **SAVAK**, the Shah's secret police, is established to control opposition.

1964 **Shia religious leader** Ayatollah Khomeini is exiled to Iraq.

1971 **Shah celebrates the 2500th** anniversary of Persian monarchy in a spectacular series of celebrations at the ancient Achaemenid capital of Persepolis.

1977 **Khomeini's son dies.** Anti-Shah demonstrations break out during the funeral and subsequent mourning.

1978 **Riots and strikes** against the Shah's government mount in Iran. Martial law is declared. Khomeini settles in Paris.

1979 **Shah goes into exile.** Ayatollah Khomeini returns from exile and declares an Islamic republic. Radical students seize 63 hostages at US embassy in Tehran.

1980 **Shah dies** in exile. Iraq invades Iran, starting an eight-year war. Iranians suffer large initial losses.

1981 **US hostages released.** Hojatoleslam Ali Khamenei elected president.

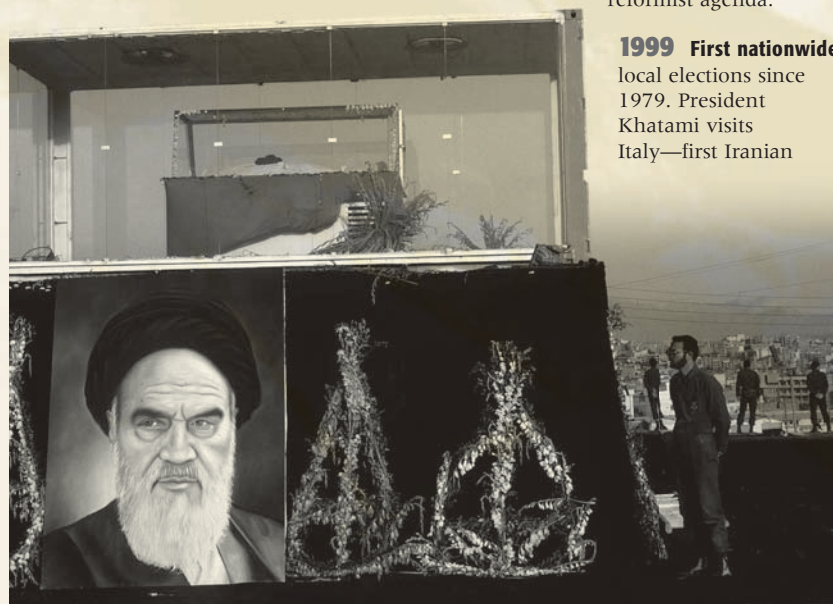
1982 **Iranians recapture** most of ground lost to Iraq and push into Iraqi territory.

1985 **Khamenei reelected** president.

1987 **Around 275 Iranian** pilgrims are killed in riots during the annual Hajj pilgrimage to Mecca.

1988 **Iranian airliner** is shot down by USS *Vincennes*; 290 people are killed. Ceasefire ends Iran–Iraq war.

1989 **Khomeini issues fatwa** condemning British author Salman Rushdie to death for alleged blasphemy in *The Satanic Verses*. Khomeini dies. President Ali Khamenei appointed supreme religious leader of Iran. Hashemi Rafsanjani elected president.



Death of Khomeini

Ruhollah Khomeini's death in 1989 deprived the Iranian revolution of the spiritual leadership he had exercised for more than a decade. His passing opened the way for more liberal movements to shape Iran's future.

PERSIAN STATESMAN (1878–1944)

SHAH REZA KHAN

Reza Khan joined the Persian Cossack Brigade at the age of 15. He rose to be the Brigade's leader and in 1921 supported a coup that reduced the last Qajar shah to a puppet. By 1923, he had become prime minister of the new regime.

Reza consolidated his power, suppressed all opposition, and in 1925 had himself declared the first shah of the new Pahlavi dynasty. He introduced a series of economic reforms that required external finance. This served to increase foreign influence in the country. He actively promoted social reform, forbidding traditional dress and the wearing of the veil by women. By the 1930s, Reza's government had become increasingly despotic and unpopular. His pro-Axis stance during World War II led the UK and USSR to occupy Iran in 1941, depose him, and install his son Mohammad Reza Pahlavi as shah. Reza Khan died in exile in South Africa.



1990 **Earthquake in northern** Iran kills 45,000 people. Iran remains neutral following Iraq's invasion of Kuwait.

1992 **Majlis elections** give a majority to reformist candidates favoring Rafsanjani.

1993 **Rafsanjani reelected** president despite campaign by Ayatollah Khamenei to eradicate Western influences.

1995 **Imposition of US** sanctions on Iran over alleged Iranian sponsorship of international terrorist groups.

1996 **Majlis elections.** Conservative Society for Combatant Clergy loses ground to more liberal factions.

1997 **Earthquake south of** Mashhad kills 1,500 people. Mohammad Khatami elected president, and begins to implement reformist agenda.

1999 **First nationwide** local elections since 1979. President Khatami visits Italy—first Iranian

leader to be received by a Western government since 1979.

2000 **Sweeping election** victory for reformists. Despite this, conservatives control many of the levers of power and there is a crackdown on reformist press.

2002 **US President** George W. Bush calls Iran a member of the "Axis of Evil."

2003 **Earthquake destroys** the medieval mud-brick city of Bam, killing over 40,000. Massive student demonstrations in Tehran end in brutal crackdown.

2004 **Conservatives win** elections to the Majlis after controversy over disqualification of reformist candidates.

2005 **Conservative mayor** of Tehran, Mahmoud Ahmadinejad, wins presidential election. He promises economic reform.

2006 **Iran announces** it has enriched uranium. UN imposes limited sanctions against Iran.

2007 **Nuclear crisis continues** as Iran declares it has begun full-scale nuclear fuel production, reinforcing fears that it aims to develop nuclear weapons.

2008 **Conservatives win** more than two-thirds of seats in parliamentary elections. Iran tests a long-range missile capable of hitting Israel.

2009 **Ahmadinejad reelected.** Violent protests alleging election fraud and a major crackdown on protesters ensues.

2010 **Iran reaches a deal** to send nuclear fuel abroad for enrichment, to Turkey and Brazil. The UN Security Council votes for expanded sanctions against Iran.

«54–55 The Cradle of Civilization
«98–99 The Greeks in Asia
«122–23 The Revival of Persia
«442–43 The Iranian Revolution